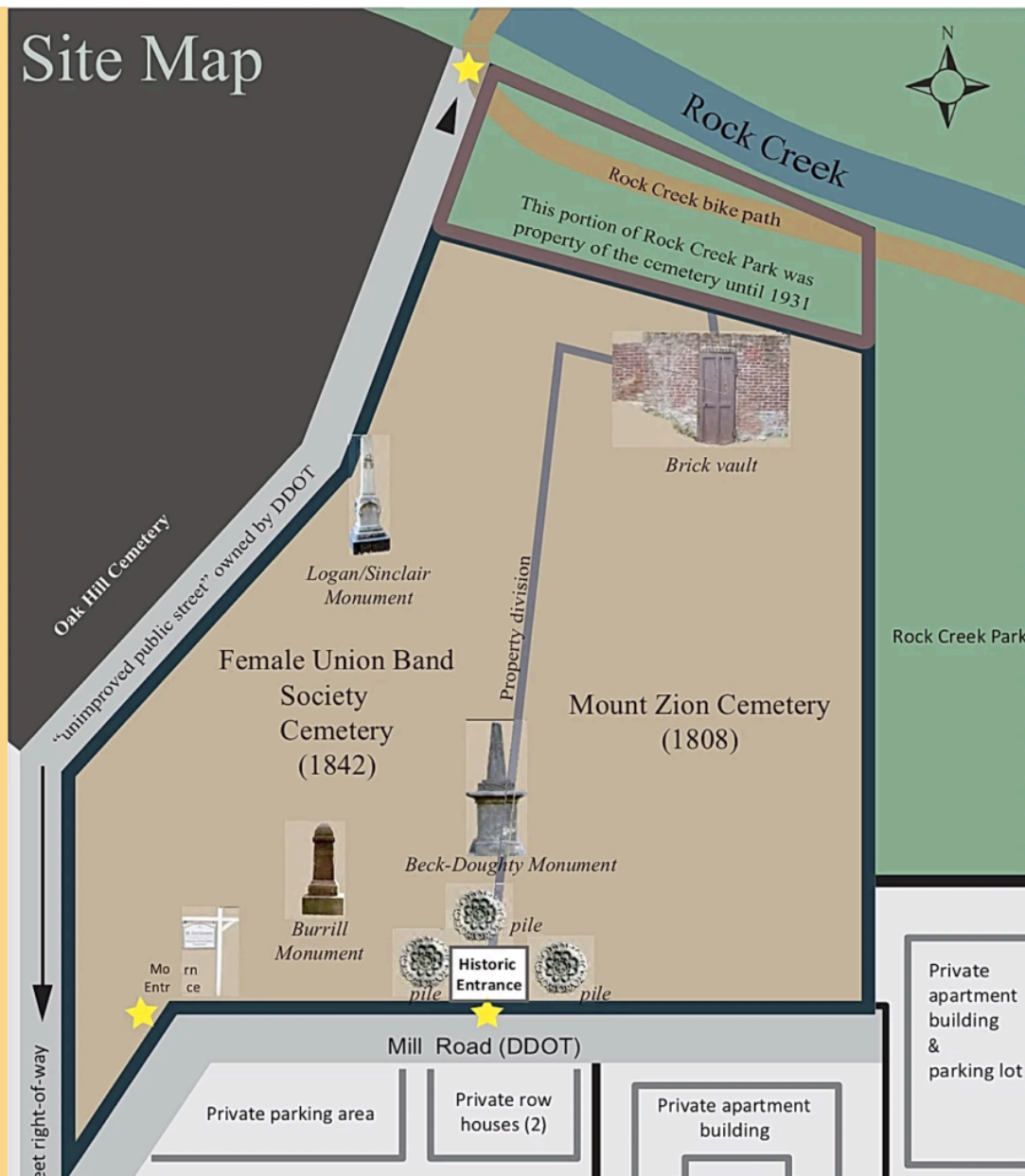


Background History

Mount Zion Cemetery:

The Mount Zion Cemetery is on the Eastern half of the Mount Zion Cemetery/Female United Band Society Cemetery plot. The Mount Zion Methodist Church was established after 125 African Americans, enslaved and free, broke away from the Montgomery Street Church in 1814 due to its segregation and discriminatory practices, the new Church was formally recognized in 1816. As Mount Zion Church's congregation grew, the need to bury their dead became apparent. In 1879, the Eastern half of the burial grounds, previously belonging to the Dumbarton Church across the road, was leased for ninety-nine years to the church for the price of \$1. The cemetery has the distinction of not only being the oldest African American burial grounds, but it was a biracial burial ground too, though there was originally a segregation fence running from the north the south sections of the cemetery.



[Site Map of the cemetery from the Mount Zion/Female Union Band Society Cemetery website](#)

Originally, the one and a half acre plot was sold to the Montgomery Street Church in 1808 by Ebenezer and Ann Elliason to the trustees of the church. Many of the white congregation members were buried there with their slaves or interred servants. The opening of the all white Oak-Hill Cemetery directly across from the Mount Zion/Female Union Band Society Cemetery in 1849 resulted in many white bodies being disinterred and moved to the exclusive white cemetery. While many slave burials, or blacks who were too poor to afford stone grave markers were allotted

wood markers, some of which still survive today, though many have been pilfered by the public as mementos and many more have rotted away from the elements over the years.

Between the 1870s and the 1890s, the Mount Zion Methodist Cemetery became known as a black cemetery. According to the *Annual Reports of the Commissioners of the District of Columbia*, there were 6,720 black people buried at Mount Zion from 1880 to 1919, compared to the 25 white burials that took place there. Despite the start of an aggressive gentrifying campaign by white residents in Georgetown, the community at Mount Zion Methodist Church was predominantly black, and even after many were forced to relocate, the congregation continued to visit their ancestors long after their forced moves out of the city. Within collective memory, Memorial Day was very popular at the cemetery, considered a time for celebration of those who lived on through the communities collective memory. Children would sell flowers, water, and lemonade while the adults would care for their ancestors' graves and reminisce about their family.

Female Union Band Society Cemetery:

Purchased in 1842, the Female Union Band Society Cemetery takes up the Western half of the collective cemetery. Originally purchased for the burial of free black women, the cemetery was a big step in African American women's independence over their own bodies. For the fee of \$4, members could expect a stipend of \$2 every month if they were sick and a stipend of \$20 for a burial, which would be enough to pay the undertaker and for a casket, a grave marker would be extra.

The society required that new members be nominated by at least two current members and be of good moral standing within the community according to its constitution from 1859. Though the society was restricted to women, it's documented that men could participate as trustees or agents, such as Joseph Mason, who originally purchased the cemetery in

1842. The society had several notable burials within, including many founding members and Phyllis Wheatley's secretary, Mary Elizabeth Thompson.

Other Notable Historic Black Cemeteries in DC:

View Historic Cemeteries in DC

[https://www.google.com/maps/d/u/0/edit?](https://www.google.com/maps/d/u/0/edit?mid=1ct2lnAgyKfnxmjdZ06NO5RpGP171AbQ&usp=sharing)

[mid=1ct2lnAgyKfnxmjdZ06NO5RpGP171AbQ&usp=sharing](https://www.google.com/maps/d/u/0/edit?mid=1ct2lnAgyKfnxmjdZ06NO5RpGP171AbQ&usp=sharing)

For reference, this map includes Oak Hill Cemetery, a historically all white cemetery.

Mount Pleasant Plains Cemetery, now part of The Walter Pierce Park Cemeteries, was the larger half of two adjoining the cemeteries. The other cemetery was the only Quaker cemetery in DC, called The Friend's Burying Ground. The cemetery was in peak use between 1880 and 1890, when the cemetery was shut down. Additionally, during the same time, across the Anacostia River, Woodlawn Cemetery grew in popularity among blacks in Georgetown. Woodlawn was considered the choice cemetery for DC's

black elite, while the cemetery across the street from it, Payne's was usually for paupers graves. Woodlawn has the highest concentration of African American interments due to other historic cemeteries being shut down for building projects. Black bodies from Graceland Cemetery, which was originally just beyond the Florida Street Boundary NE. The [Columbian Harmony Cemetery](#) also interred many black bodies during the 1870s-1890s.

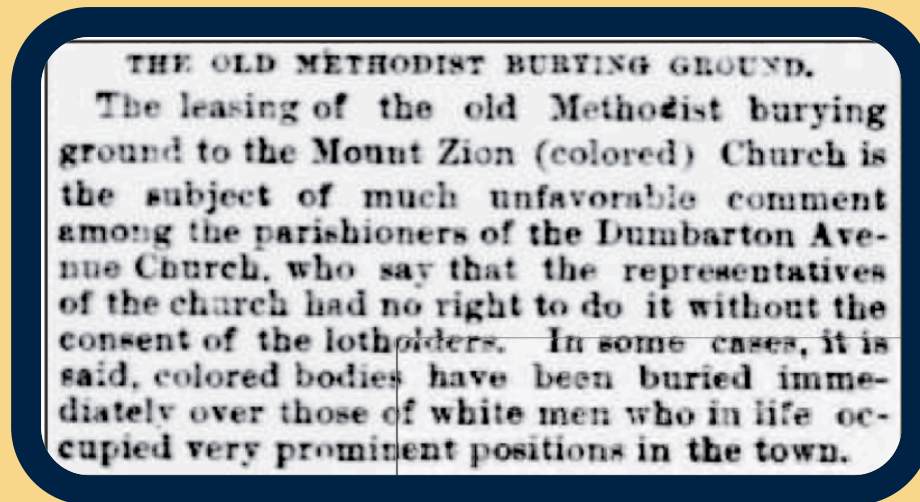
There were several benevolent societies within Georgetown, in addition to the Female Union Band Society. After the abolition of slavery, societies were set up to support poor blacks via their own communities. Societies like the Female Union Band Society included, the Southern Aid Society of Virginia, the United Sons of Salem Benevolent Society, and the local Union Burial Society of Georgetown Cemetery. These societies relied heavily on their communities, usually belonging to the same congregation or living on the same street, to fundraise for burials and headstones for local community members.

African American Burial Practices:

From the 1870s to the 1890s, when many of these cemeteries were at the height of their popularity and use, Victorian funeral customs were present in African American burial practices in Georgetown. With a decline in the belief of predestination, emphasis on mourning and more personalized grave markers became popular. In many ways, African American Burial practices were similar to Anglo-American "norms" of the day, for example, family members of the deceased wore black, the outside of the casket was decorated, and the clothes of the deceased were carefully selected.

Where funerals differed was in the celebration of the deceased life. Anglo-American funerals were considered a tragic affair, with heavy emphasis placed on mourning rituals and the moral purity of the deceased. Whereas black funerals were more of a celebration of life, one

where the community would come together to celebrate together, this tradition carried over from slavery where a funeral was seen as a slave's final chance for expression in life.



The Evening Star, 1893. A reaction to burial practices at the Mount Zion Methodist Church Cemetery.

The Newspaper Reads:

"The Old Methodist Burying Ground

The leasing of the old Methodist burying ground to the Mount Zion (colored) Church is the subject of much unfavorable comment among parishioners of the Dumbarton Avenue Church, who say that the representatives of the church had no right to do it without the consent of the lotholders. In some cases, it is said, colored bodies have been buried immediately over those of white men who in life occupied very prominent positions in the town."

References:

Kaliff, Rebecca. n.d. "What Lies Beneath: Documenting the History of the Columbian Harmony Cemetery – Humanities Truck." Accessed April 25, 2023. <https://humanitiestruck.com/what-lies-beneath/>.

Mitchell, Pauline Gaskins, Kathleen Menzie Lesko, Valerie Babb, and Carroll R. Gibbs. "Appendix 3: Mount Zion Cemetery." In *Black Georgetown Remembered: A History of Its Black Community from the Founding of "The Town of George" in 1751 to the Present Day*, 169–76. Georgetown University Press, 2016. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt19x3h6j.12>.

Mitchell, Pauline Gaskins. "The History of Mt. Zion United Methodist Church and Mt. Zion Cemetery." *Records of the Columbia Historical Society, Washington, D.C.* 51 (1984): 103–18.
<http://www.jstor.org/stable/40067847>.

National Park Service U.S. Department of the Interior. "Mount Zion Cemetery/Females Union Band Cemetery." Historic American Landscapes Survey. 2008. https://www.mtzion-fubs.org/files/ugd/148a5e_0e1546b5c0bb42599e96e1741bd129d4.pdf

Renchard, Stella Mae, and Stella Mae Richards. "TWO HIDDEN CEMETERIES: In the Georgetown Section of Washington, D.C." *Negro History Bulletin* 32, no. 7 (1969): 29–30.
<http://www.jstor.org/stable/24767078>.

Richardson, Steven J. "The Burial Grounds of Black Washington: 1880–1919." *Records of the Columbia Historical Society, Washington, D.C.* 52 (1989): 304–26. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/40067870>.

"HISTORY | Mount Zion – Female Union Band Society Historic Georgetown Cemetery." n.d. Mt Zion-FUBSCemetery.
<https://www.mtzion-fubs.org/history>.

"Mount Zion United Methodist Church – the Mount Zion United Methodist Church Is One of the Oldest Black Churches in All of DC." n.d. DC Historic Sites. Accessed April 25, 2023.
<https://historicsites.dcpreservation.org/items/show/401>. "The Walter Pierce Park Cemeteries." n.d. The Walter Pierce Park Cemeteries. Accessed April 25, 2023. <https://walterpierceparkcemeteries.org/>.

DC Black Cemeteries

Proudly powered by [WordPress](#)